

Stakeholders in the Okavango Delta's Water Management, Wildlife Conservation, and Tourism (Botswana, Namibia, Angola)

Introduction: The Okavango Delta is a transboundary wetland system spanning three countries – Botswana, Namibia, and Angola – each of which plays a role in managing its water resources, conserving its rich wildlife, and developing sustainable tourism. Effective stewardship of the Delta involves a diverse network of stakeholders, including government agencies, non-governmental organizations (NGOs), community-based organizations, and private sector players. Below, we identify key stakeholders by **sector** (water management, wildlife conservation, tourism) and by **country**, with brief descriptions of their roles. We also note regional cooperative bodies that link the three nations in managing the Okavango basin.

Water Management Stakeholders

The Okavango is a single river-basin system, so water management is highly collaborative. All three countries are members of the **Permanent Okavango River Basin Water Commission (OKACOM)**, a tri-national body established in 1994 to jointly advise on sustainable use of the Okavango/Cubango River's resources ¹ ². OKACOM's mandate is to ensure coordinated, environmentally sound development that meets each country's needs without harming the Delta's flow or ecology ³ ⁴. In addition to OKACOM, each country has its own agencies and local actors managing water supply, quality, and basin planning, as outlined in **Table 1**.

Table 1. Key Water Management Stakeholders in the Okavango Basin (by country and sector role):

Botswana (downstream Delta)	Namibia (mid-stream)	Angola (upstream headwaters)
Government: Ministry of Land Management, Water & Sanitation Services – formulates water policy ⁵ ; Department of Water Affairs – manages water resources and hydrological monitoring in the Delta. Department of Environmental Affairs – leads wetland management planning (e.g. Okavango Delta Management Plan) to fulfill Ramsar obligations.
 Regional Body: OKACOM National Commission – Botswana’s delegation to OKACOM for transboundary water decisions. ¹	Government: Ministry of Agriculture, Water and Land Reform – oversees water use (irrigation, domestic supply) in the Namibian stretch of the Okavango (“Kavango” River). Department of Water Affairs – monitors river flow and quality along the Namibia–Angola border. The Ministry of Environment, Forestry & Tourism (MEFT) – coordinates with neighbors on shared water impacts (e.g. ensuring upstream projects undergo EIA) ¹.
 Regional Body: OKACOM National Commission – Namibia’s representatives to the basin commission.	Government: Ministry of Energy and Water (MINEA) – responsible for water resources in Angola’s Cubango and Cuito river catchments. Provincial Government of Cuando Cubango – local authority in the headwaters region, involved in water and land-use planning.
 Regional Body: OKACOM National Commission – Angola’s delegation to OKACOM, advising on basin-wide water allocation and development ¹.
Community/NGO: Okavango Basin Steering Committee (multi-stakeholder forum under OKACOM) – includes local community input from Botswana’s Okavango district. Local village trusts and water user groups (e.g. farmers and fisherfolk in the Delta panhandle) engage in consultations on water management ⁶ ⁷. The Okavango Research Institute (University of Botswana) – conducts hydrological and ecological research to inform water planning, and participates in community outreach ⁸.	Community/NGO: Namibia Nature Foundation (NNF) – led the “Every River Has Its People” project to involve riparian communities in basin management ⁶ ⁹. Local Traditional Authorities (e.g. the vaKwangali, vaMbukushu chiefs in Kavango East/West) represent community water interests. Community trusts and conservancies in Kavango regions work on water-related livelihoods (e.g. community gardens, fishery co-management) ¹⁰ ¹¹.	Community/NGO: ACADIR (Associação de Conservação do Ambiente e Desenvolvimento Integrado Rural) – a locally led NGO in Cuando Cubango that empowers communities in river basin management, sustainable fishing, and water-resource governance ¹² ¹³. ACADIR helps villages in the headwaters practice conservation that protects streams and wetlands. Traditional community leaders in Cuito and Cubango sub-basins also coordinate local use of water for agriculture and drinking needs.

Botswana (downstream Delta)	Namibia (mid-stream)	Angola (upstream headwaters)
Private Sector: (Limited direct private water extraction in the Delta – the area is mostly protected.) However, safari lodge operators in the Delta rely on the natural water flows and thus often support water monitoring (as stakeholders interested in maintaining Delta hydrology). The Water Utilities Corporation (parastatal) supplies treated water to Maun (gateway town to the Delta). Potential commercial water users are minimal, as Botswana has pledged to keep the Delta free of large dams or irrigation that could alter flows ¹⁴ ¹ .	Private Sector: Commercial irrigation farmers in the Kavango regions (e.g. small-scale crop schemes near Rundu) depend on Okavango River water and are stakeholders in water allocation discussions. NamWater (Namibia Water Corporation) – provides water for urban centers (like Rundu) from the river and must coordinate on any abstraction plans. There are no major dams on the Okavango in Namibia; any proposal for water diversion (e.g. pipeline plans) would involve these stakeholders in national and OKACOM dialogues.	Private Sector: Currently, there are no large private water infrastructure projects in the Angolan headwaters – the rivers remain almost undeveloped ¹⁵ . However, proposed land investments (for irrigation or hydropower) would make Angolan agribusiness and energy companies key stakeholders. For now, demining contractors (e.g. HALO Trust) indirectly support water management by clearing explosives from riverbanks, enabling safe hydrological surveys and future community water projects ¹⁶ .

Notes: Botswana’s Okavango Delta was designated a *Ramsar Wetland of International Importance* in 1996, and Namibia’s portion (Bwabwata-Okavango) became a Ramsar site in 2013 ¹⁷ . This status means water management plans must prioritize ecological sustainability. Through OKACOM, the three governments have agreed that any major upstream development (dams, irrigation) must undergo rigorous environmental impact assessment with basin-wide consultation ¹ ¹⁸ . This collaborative governance helps protect the Delta’s hydrology for the benefit of all riparian communities.

Wildlife Conservation Stakeholders

Conserving the Okavango Delta’s wildlife – from mega-fauna like elephants and lions to hundreds of bird species – is a shared priority across Botswana, Namibia, and Angola. Much of the Delta and its upstream catchment is within the **Kavango–Zambezi Transfrontier Conservation Area (KAZA TFCA)**, a five-country initiative (Angola, Botswana, Namibia, Zambia, Zimbabwe) that aims to create a vast connected landscape for wildlife and ecotourism ¹⁹ ²⁰ . Within KAZA, Angola and Botswana harbor critical elephant ranges, and Namibia’s Caprivi/Kavango provides a migratory corridor ²¹ ²² . Key stakeholders in wildlife conservation are listed by country in **Table 2**.

Table 2. Key Wildlife Conservation Stakeholders (government, NGOs, community, private) **in the Okavango region:**

Botswana (Okavango Delta)**

Government: Department of Wildlife & National Parks (DWNP) – manages protected areas and wildlife in Botswana, including **Moremi Game Reserve** (which covers ~40% of the Delta) ²³. DWNP enforces the Wildlife Conservation & National Parks Act (1992) ²³ and runs anti-poaching, research, and wildlife monitoring (e.g. annual aerial surveys) ²⁴ ²⁵. The Ministry of Environment, Natural Resources Conservation & Tourism (MENT) oversees DWNP and sets national conservation policy. Tribal Land Authorities (Tawana Land Board) control the Wildlife Management Areas (WMAs) that make up the rest of the Delta, where wildlife use is regulated via zoning and permits ²³ ²⁶.

Namibia (Kavango & Caprivi)

Government: Ministry of Environment, Forestry & Tourism (MEFT) – responsible for wildlife conservation nationwide, including **Bwabwata National Park** and **Khaudum National Park**, which lie in the Okavango Basin. MEFT works with communal conservancies in the Kavango and Zambezi regions to manage wildlife on community lands. It issues wildlife use quotas (for tourism or limited hunting) and has placed a high priority on human-wildlife conflict mitigation and anti-poaching. MEFT also represents Namibia in KAZA TFCA and coordinates transboundary wildlife initiatives (e.g. elephant monitoring across borders).

Angola (Cuando Cubango)

Government: Ministry of Environment (Ministério do Ambiente) – oversees Angola’s nascent protected areas in the Okavango headwaters. Two large parks, **Luengue-Luiana** and **Mavinga**, were established in Cuando Cubango as part of KAZA, aiming to restore wildlife in this post-conflict landscape. The Ministry sets conservation policy and works on reintroducing wildlife that disappeared during Angola’s civil war ²⁷ ¹⁶. The **National Institute of Biodiversity and Conservation Areas** (INBAC) helps manage parks and wildlife. Local (provincial) government in Cuando Cubango also engages in wildlife protection efforts, often in partnership with NGOs (e.g. coordinating anti-poaching patrols and community outreach).

NGOs & Academia: *Kalahari Conservation Society (KCS)* – a Botswana NGO involved in research and advocacy for conservation in the Okavango, including community education and policy input. *Elephants Without Borders* – conducts elephant population research (the Delta hosts ~130,000 elephants, the world's largest herd ²⁸) and works on human-elephant coexistence. *BirdLife Botswana* – monitors important bird areas in the Delta and helps combat threats like invasive species (e.g. *Salvinia* weed) that affect wetland birds. *Okavango Research Institute (ORI)* – University of Botswana's research center in Maun, which provides science on Delta ecosystems and advises management; ORI experts often participate in multi-stakeholder forums ⁸. Botswana is also supported by international NGOs: e.g., *World Wildlife Fund (WWF)* and *Conservation International* have projects through KAZA to enhance habitat connectivity and community-based conservation.

NGOs & Academia: *Integrated Rural Development and Nature Conservation (IRDNC)* – Namibian NGO that pioneered the community conservancy model; IRDNC supports conservancies in Kavango/Zambezi (training game guards, facilitating benefit-sharing from wildlife). *Namibia Nature Foundation (NNF)* – has run projects in the Okavango region (e.g. fisheries co-management, conservancy support) ⁶. *Worldwide Fund for Nature (WWF-Namibia)* – provides funding and technical help to communal conservancies and KAZA initiatives (e.g. wildlife corridors). *NACSO* (Namibian Assoc. of CBNRM Support Organizations) – umbrella body including IRDNC, NNF, government, etc., coordinating support to community wildlife management. Academic partners like the University of Namibia and Namibia University of Science & Technology conduct research on wildlife ecology and advise on conservation planning in the Kavango region.

NGOs & International: *Wild Bird Trust – National Geographic Okavango Wilderness Project (NGOWP)* – has been exploring Angola's "water tower" since 2015, surveying wildlife and working with government to create conservation plans ²⁹ ³⁰. NGOWP's findings have supported Angola in identifying key biodiversity areas and designing protected areas. *Kissama Foundation* – an Angolan conservation NGO known for reintroducing elephants to Angola; it partners in wildlife monitoring and capacity building (it's listed as a supporter of the Okavango Wilderness Project) ³¹. *Panthera* – involved in carnivore research in Angola (e.g. surveying lions, leopards in KAZA parks). *Halo Trust* – though primarily a demining NGO, Halo's work clearing landmines in wildlife habitats has been critical for enabling animals (and rangers) to move freely again ¹⁶, effectively supporting wildlife recovery. Academic collaboration is growing; for instance, Agostinho Neto University (Angola) and international researchers are studying the headwaters' ecology to guide conservation.

Community Organizations: Community-Based Natural Resource Management (CBNRM) Trusts – local community trusts manage wildlife areas in the Delta's multiple-use zones. For example, the **Okavango Community Trust (OCT)** represents five villages (Seronga, Beetsha, Gudigwa, Eretsha, Gunotsoga) and holds the rights to wildlife utilization in NG22/NG23 concession areas ³² ³³. OCT and similar trusts (e.g. **Khwai Development Trust** in Khwai village, **Sankuyo Tshwaragano Management Trust** in Sankuyo) partner with safari operators to manage wildlife sustainably and derive income from photographic tourism or formerly hunting. These communities participate in anti-poaching patrols and wildlife monitoring on their lands, incentivized by earnings from wildlife-based tourism ³⁴ ³⁵. Traditional leaders (chiefs) in Ngamiland also have a say in wildlife management policies, ensuring that indigenous knowledge and concerns (like human-wildlife conflict, cultural uses of wildlife) are heard.

Community Organizations: Communal Conservancies – Namibia's hallmark community conservation units. In the Okavango basin, conservancies like **George Mukoya** and **Muduva Nyangana** (in Kavango East, north of Khaudum Park) empower local communities to manage wildlife and habitat ³⁶. They receive quotas for sustainable hunting or tourism which fund community development ³⁷ ³⁸. These conservancies often form joint ventures with tour operators for wildlife viewing camps, and their members serve as community game guards watching over wildlife. In the Zambezi Region's eastern Caprivi Strip, conservancies (e.g. **Bamunu, Wuparo**) manage wildlife corridors that link to the Okavango-Chobe system, and the **Kyaramacan Association** represents community members inside Bwabwata National Park, allowing residents (mostly Khwe San people) to benefit from park wildlife. Local Traditional Authorities (such as the Mbukushu and Hambukushu chiefs in Kavango) collaborate with conservancies, blending traditional stewardship with modern conservation practices ³⁹.

Community Organizations: Angola is in early stages of community-based conservation. **ACADIR** (mentioned above) has been instrumental in organizing village committees for natural resource management ⁴⁰ ¹². These community institutions work on activities like wildlife monitoring (reporting sightings of returning elephants, for instance) and mitigating human-wildlife conflict as animals reoccupy the region. Traditional community leaders (e.g. sobas) are being engaged to support conservation goals, and the government and NGOs aim to formalize community conservancies similar to Namibia's model. As security improves, communities are being trained in skills like tracking and anti-poaching, so they can be employed as rangers and guides – linking their well-being with wildlife protection ⁴¹ ⁴².

Botswana (Okavango Delta)**	Namibia (Kavango & Caprivi)	Angola (Cuando Cubango)
Private Sector: Tourism operators play a big role in wildlife conservation in Botswana. Companies such as <i>Wilderness Safaris</i>, <i>&Beyond</i>, and <i>Desert & Delta Safaris</i> operate lodges in the Delta's wildlife areas. By concession agreements, they must follow wildlife management guidelines and often fund conservation initiatives (anti-poaching units, research, etc.) on their concession lands. Private photographic safari operators have contributed to wildlife surveys (e.g. sharing data from their own aerial game counts) ²⁵. Safari hunting operators (prior to the 2014 hunting ban) were also stakeholders, working with communities on quota-managed hunting – today, most of the Delta is for photographic tourism only, but hunting remains in some peripheral WMAs. Additionally, Wildlife-based NGOs founded or funded by the private sector (for example, the <i>Wilderness Wildlife Trust</i>) support research on species like African wild dogs. The Botswana Predator Conservation Trust (a research NGO near the Delta) is partially supported by tourism revenue.	Private Sector: In Namibia's Okavango regions, professional hunting outfits and photographic safari companies are stakeholders. Some conservancies in Kavango still have regulated hunting concessions – professional hunters (often international operators) generate income for communities via trophy fees, giving locals a stake in preserving species like buffalo and crocodiles ⁷ ⁴³. Meanwhile, tourism lodge companies (e.g. <i>Gondwana Collection</i> or <i>Namushasha Lodge</i> in Zambezi) are expanding into the Kavango area; they work with conservancies (hiring local staff, paying lease fees) and assist with wildlife monitoring on conservancy land. Private veterinarians and farmers along the Botswana/Namibia border are stakeholders in wildlife health issues – for instance, managing foot-and-mouth disease via veterinary fences has huge wildlife implications ⁴⁴, so the farming sector's interests intersect with conservation policy.	Private Sector: Private investment in wildlife tourism in Angola's Okavango hinterland is still nascent. However, Angola's government is seeking eco-tourism investors to develop lodges and safari operations in Cuando Cubango ⁴⁵ ⁴⁶. International safari companies and some Namibian operators have shown interest in expanding into Angola once infrastructure and safety improve ⁴⁷. Mining and oil companies also emerge as indirect stakeholders – e.g. petroleum exploration by ReconAfrica in Namibia/Angola has raised concerns for wildlife and water. The Angolan government's stance (as of 2023) is cautious, with conservation stakeholders pushing to prioritize wildlife and tourism over extractive industries ⁴⁸ ⁴⁹. In summary, while the private sector for wildlife in Angola is currently limited, plans under KAZA envision public-private partnerships to fund park management and wildlife reintroductions (possibly involving groups like <i>African Parks</i> in the future).

Notes: The **KAZA TFCA Secretariat** (based in Botswana) is itself a stakeholder, coordinating conservation across borders. All three countries' wildlife authorities collaborate through KAZA on initiatives like the **KAZA Elephant Conservation Strategy**, since the region hosts Earth's largest contiguous elephant population ²¹ ²². Transboundary anti-poaching operations are also crucial: Botswana, Namibia, and Angola have begun to share intelligence and coordinate patrols as wildlife moves freely across their frontiers (for example, elephants now roam back into southeast Angola as minefields are cleared ¹⁶ ⁴¹). Engaging local communities is recognized as vital for success – UNESCO has even supported programs (COMPACT grants) to **"enhance governance mechanisms to empower stakeholders"**, including indigenous Delta communities, in World Heritage site management ⁵⁰. The wildlife conservation stakeholder landscape is

thus a mosaic of governments, communities, NGOs, and private actors working together to keep the Okavango wild.

Tourism Stakeholders

The Okavango Delta is a world-renowned tourism destination, especially in Botswana where high-end safari tourism in the Delta is a major economic driver. Namibia and Angola, while not as globally famous for Okavango tourism, are integral to the region’s emerging tourism network: Namibia’s Caprivi strip offers access to the Delta’s fringes, and Angola’s scenic headwaters hold future eco-tourism potential as part of the broader Okavango basin experience. Tourism stakeholders range from national tourism boards and ministries, to local community enterprises, to safari companies. **Table 3** outlines the key players in tourism by country.

Table 3. Key Tourism Stakeholders in the Okavango Delta Region:

Botswana (core Delta tourism)	Namibia (Kavango/Caprivi tourism)	Angola (Cuando Cubango tourism)
Government Agencies: <i>Ministry of Environment, Natural Resources, Conservation, and Tourism</i> – sets tourism policy and licensing, aiming for low-impact, high-value tourism in the Okavango. <i>Botswana Tourism Organisation (BTO)</i> – a parastatal that markets Botswana’s destinations (the Delta being the flagship) and supports product development. BTO also classifies tourism facilities and has invested in community tourism projects. <i>Department of Tourism</i> – regulates tourist guiding, accommodations, and enforces quality standards. Local government (Ngamiland District Council) coordinates with these agencies on land-use zoning for camps and tourist access infrastructure.	Government Agencies: <i>Ministry of Environment, Forestry & Tourism (MEFT)</i> – oversees tourism policy (previously the Ministry of Environment and Tourism, MET ⁵¹) and works to integrate tourism with conservation (e.g. promoting community campsites). <i>Namibia Tourism Board (NTB)</i> – responsible for tourism marketing and grading of establishments; NTB includes the Kavango and Zambezi regions in its promotional circuits (often branding them as part of the broader Okavango–Kavango experience). Regional and local authorities (e.g. Kavango East and West Regional Councils) have tourism offices that facilitate development of tourist routes and events (like cultural festivals) along the Okavango River. Namibia also collaborates in <i>RETOSA (Regional Tourism Organization of Southern Africa)</i> for cross-border tourism initiatives ⁵².	Government Agencies: <i>Ministry of Tourism</i> (or Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Environment) – leads Angola’s efforts to open Cuando Cubango for tourism. Angola established a Okavango Basin Tourism Development Board (Pólo de Desenvolvimento do Turismo do Basin do Okavango, PDTBO) as a focal institution to plan and promote tourism in the Okavango region ¹⁹ ⁵³. The Provincial Government of Cuando Cubango also plays a key role, addressing practical issues like road access, border post openings, and investment incentives ⁵⁴ ⁵⁵. Notably, Angola is part of the KAZA TFCA treaty (signed but pending full ratification) ²⁰, meaning its government is committed to transboundary tourism and conservation – exemplified by recent funding of an international airport in Mavinga to improve access to the Okavango area ⁵⁶ ⁵⁷.

Botswana (core Delta tourism)	Namibia (Kavango/Caprivi tourism)	Angola (Cuando Cubango tourism)
Community-Based Tourism: Community trusts in Botswana's Delta not only manage wildlife but also run tourism enterprises. For example, the Sankuyo Tshwaragano Trust operates Santawani Lodge, a community-owned safari lodge near Moremi Game Reserve ³⁴ ⁵⁸. This lodge, fully managed by local residents, was one of the first to demonstrate that communities can directly benefit from tourism – its profits fund local health and education, while also incentivizing wildlife conservation on 8,000 hectares of community-leased land ⁵⁹ ⁶⁰. Similarly, the Khwai Development Trust manages campsites (like Magotho) popular with self-drive tourists, and the Okavango Community Trust leases its concessions (hosting luxury camps) to private operators but earns substantial revenues for village development ⁶¹ ³⁵. These trusts represent the interests of rural communities, ensuring they have a voice in Delta tourism planning and share in its gains. Cultural tourism groups (e.g. mokoro polers' associations comprised of Bayei people) are also notable stakeholders – they offer traditional canoe excursions in the Delta and are organized to secure fair wages and preserve indigenous knowledge for tourism.	Community-Based Tourism: Communal Conservancies double as tourism stakeholders in Namibia. Conservancies along the Okavango (like George Mukoya and Muduva Nyangana) have joint-venture agreements with tour operators to run lodges or campsites ³⁶ ⁶². They earn bed-night levies and employment for members. There are also standalone community campsites established with donor support – e.g. the Mbamba Campsite in Joseph Mbambangandu Conservancy was set up to attract tourists off the beaten path ⁶³ ⁶⁴. The Kavango Regional Tourism Forum, created under the “Every River Has Its People” project, helped link these community campsites into a <i>Kavango Tourism Route</i> connecting to routes in Botswana and Angola ⁶³ ⁶⁵. Traditional crafts cooperatives (mostly women) in all five Kavango traditional authority areas produce handicrafts for sale to tourists ⁶⁶ ⁶⁷ – an important community-driven tourism livelihood that also keeps cultural heritage alive. Overall, Namibian communities (through conservancies and small businesses) are key in offering cultural tours, managing camps, and guiding fishing or birding trips on the Okavango River.	Community-Based Tourism: Angola's local communities are at the early stages of tourism involvement, but authorities plan for “community tourism” to be a cornerstone of Okavango development ⁴². Once demining and basic facilities are in place, communities such as the Mbunda, Khwe (San), and Nganguela peoples can serve as guides and hosts – as Angola's PDTBO director noted, “They are the best guides... they will show what the tourist is looking for” ⁴². Already, communities have been engaged in cultural events for the few visitors (for example, welcoming the “Raid Okavango” expedition of adventure tourists ⁶⁸). NGOs like ACADIR are working to build community capacity so that local people can run campsites and benefit from any tourism growth, rather than outsiders exclusively. Angola's vision is that after initial infrastructure (like campsites and border posts) is established, community members will gain jobs as rangers, trackers, guides, and hospitality staff – thus community-based tourism, though nascent, is a planned pillar for inclusive development of the Okavango region ⁴¹ ⁴².

Private Sector (Tour Operators & Investors): The private safari industry is **highly influential** in the Okavango Delta. Companies such as **Wilderness Safaris** and **&Beyond** operate numerous high-end camps within the Delta, controlling prime wildlife locations. These operators, often foreign-owned, historically captured the bulk of tourism profits ³⁵. (A study noted that ~81.5% of tourist facilities in the Delta region had foreign investment influence ⁶⁹.) They are stakeholders in policy discussions (through bodies like HATAB – the Hospitality and Tourism Association of Botswana) and have partnered with government on conservation (e.g. Wilderness Safaris co-funds anti-poaching). Many also have charitable arms supporting community development. Other private stakeholders include **Maun-based tour operators** (who run scenic flights, mokoro excursions, etc.), and the airlines/charter companies that ferry tourists into the Delta's camps. **Hotel groups** (like Belmond, which runs lodges in the Delta) and **mobile safari operators** are also part of the tourism ecosystem. These private actors have a vested interest in maintaining the Delta's World Heritage status and pristine condition (as it is the selling point for tourism) ⁷⁰ ⁷¹. In recent years, there is a push for partnerships so that private companies mentor community trusts (as seen with the Santawani Lodge handover)

Private Sector (Tour Operators & Investors): The Namibian side of the Okavango sees a mix of **small lodge operators** and **regional safari companies**. For instance, lodges like *Hakusembe River Lodge* (Gondwana Collection) near Rundu, or *Ngepi Camp* in Kavango, cater to tourists seeking a river experience. While tourism here is smaller-scale than Botswana, private operators are keen to develop “river and culture” experiences that complement a Delta safari (e.g. offering boat rides, village visits). Some Botswana-based companies extend into Namibia's Caprivi – for example, *Desert & Delta Safaris* runs Chobe region properties and could integrate Caprivi/Okavango offerings. **Fishing tour operators** also operate on the Namibian Okavango (targeting tigerfish), often in partnership with local camps. Namibian private sector participates in transboundary tourism marketing through KAZA; for example, the KAZA *UniVisa* (between Zimbabwe and Zambia, with hopes to include Namibia/Botswana) is an initiative supported by tour operators to ease cross-border travel. Investment-wise, Namibian entrepreneurs have been encouraged to develop more lodges in Kavango, with government incentives. However, a challenge has been lower tourist traffic; thus, NTB and private sector are jointly promoting the Kavango as a

Private Sector (Tour Operators & Investors): At present, **private tourism in Angola's Okavango region is limited**, but ambitious plans are underway. The government is actively courting **investors to build lodges** and tour operations in Cuando Cubango ⁴⁵. For example, in 2024 Angola announced that several campsites would be established and then offered to private concessionaires to manage ⁴⁷ ⁷³. Neighboring countries' tour operators are seen as potential entrants – **Namibian operators** with experience in Caprivi have been invited to help jumpstart Angolan camps, given cultural and language affinities ⁴⁶. A few adventure tourism events (“Raid Okavango” off-road rally, etc.) have been organized by private groups to scout the area's tourism potential ⁶⁸. In terms of broader private investment, Angola views tourism as a strategic alternative to resource extraction; President João Lourenço's administration has highlighted Okavango as a priority for eco-tourism investment ⁵⁶. This includes public-private partnerships to build access (the new Mavinga airport construction is contracted to private firms with state funds ⁵⁶). Once security (mine clearance) is improved, one can expect the private safari industry (possibly including international brands or African ecotourism companies) to move in as key stakeholders, shaping Angola's

Botswana (core Delta tourism)	Namibia (Kavango/Caprivi tourism)	Angola (Cuando Cubango tourism)
⁵⁹ ⁷² , aligning private profit motives with local empowerment.	detour for self-drive tourists and an add-on for those visiting the Delta.	Okavango tourism in partnership with the government and communities.

Notes: Across all three countries, **international development partners** also play a role in tourism sector support. For instance, UNESCO’s World Heritage Fund and UNDP have provided small grants (COMPACT) to Okavango Delta community projects to ensure local people share tourism benefits ⁷⁴ ⁷⁵ . USAID and NGOs like African Wildlife Foundation have funded training and marketing for community lodges in Botswana ⁷² ⁷⁶ . In Angola, the Okavango Wilderness Project (NatGeo) and others are helping to lay the groundwork for community-based tourism by securing conservation commitments and basic infrastructure ²⁹ ¹⁶ .

Finally, it’s worth noting the **interdependence** of these stakeholders: water management decisions upstream directly impact wildlife and tourism downstream. Thus, forums are increasingly integrating sectors – for example, transboundary **technical meetings** have brought together water engineers, park managers, community representatives, and tourism boards to discuss the Okavango Delta’s future ⁸ ⁷⁷ . The stakeholder landscape is therefore not siloed by sector, but rather a connected network working toward the common goal of a sustainable Okavango Delta that continues to support ecosystems, livelihoods, and a thriving tourism economy for generations to come.

Sources:

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- UNESCO World Heritage Centre – Okavango Delta reports (governance, community engagement, transboundary efforts) ²⁴ ²³ ⁵⁰
- National Geographic Okavango Wilderness Project – stakeholder partnerships (Angola ministries, KAZA, etc.) ³¹ ⁷⁹
- African Wildlife Foundation (AWF) – community lodge case study (Sankuyo Trust, Botswana) ³⁴ ⁵⁹
- OKACOM/UNDP Project report – Namibia conservancies’ tourism concession in Khaudum area ³⁶ ⁶²
- “Every River Has Its People” project summary – community involvement in basin management and tourism (Namibia/Botswana) ⁶ ⁶³
- ACADIR (Angola NGO) – mission in community-based conservation in Cuando Cubango ¹³ ¹²
- VerAngola News (Nov 2023) – Angola’s Okavango tourism development plans (government and KAZA focal point quotes) ¹⁶ ⁴¹ .

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